

GTA Housing Affordability

Dashboard Report · Where is renting affordable, for whom?

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Overview

Most affordability reporting treats the Greater Toronto Area as a single market and quotes one regional number. That number hides more than it reveals: a renter in Toronto and a renter in Halton Hills are facing very different realities, even when the headline figures look similar. This project builds a municipality-level view of rent affordability across 25 GTA municipalities, comparing rent against income rather than relying on rent alone, so that the places where renters are actually under pressure don't get averaged away.

The dashboard brings together five KPIs the team set out to answer: how rent compares to income by municipality, how much income a household needs to afford a 2-bedroom unit, what share of renters are cost-burdened (spending more than 30% of income on rent), how rental choice (vacancy) varies by city, and how rent growth compares to income growth over time.

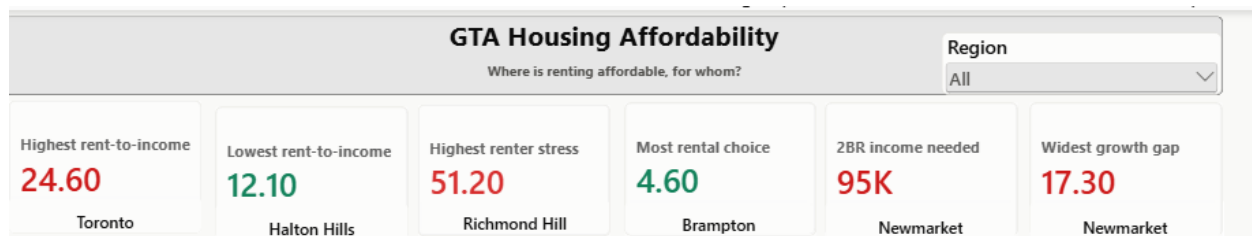
Data & Methodology

Rent figures come from CMHC's Housing Market Survey; income figures come from Statistics Canada's census data, joined at the municipality level. The data moves through a pipeline: raw CMHC and StatCan tables are loaded into a lakehouse, cleaned and joined by municipality, aggregated into KPIs with SQL, and finally visualized in Power BI. 2025 income is estimated by carrying forward 2020 census income with inflation, since more recent census income figures are not yet published.

Dashboard Walkthrough

The dashboard is built from four visual types, each chosen for what it's good at: scorecards for headline numbers, a bar chart for side-by-side comparison, a conditionally formatted table for scanning many values at once, and a line chart for change over time.

1. KPI Scorecards

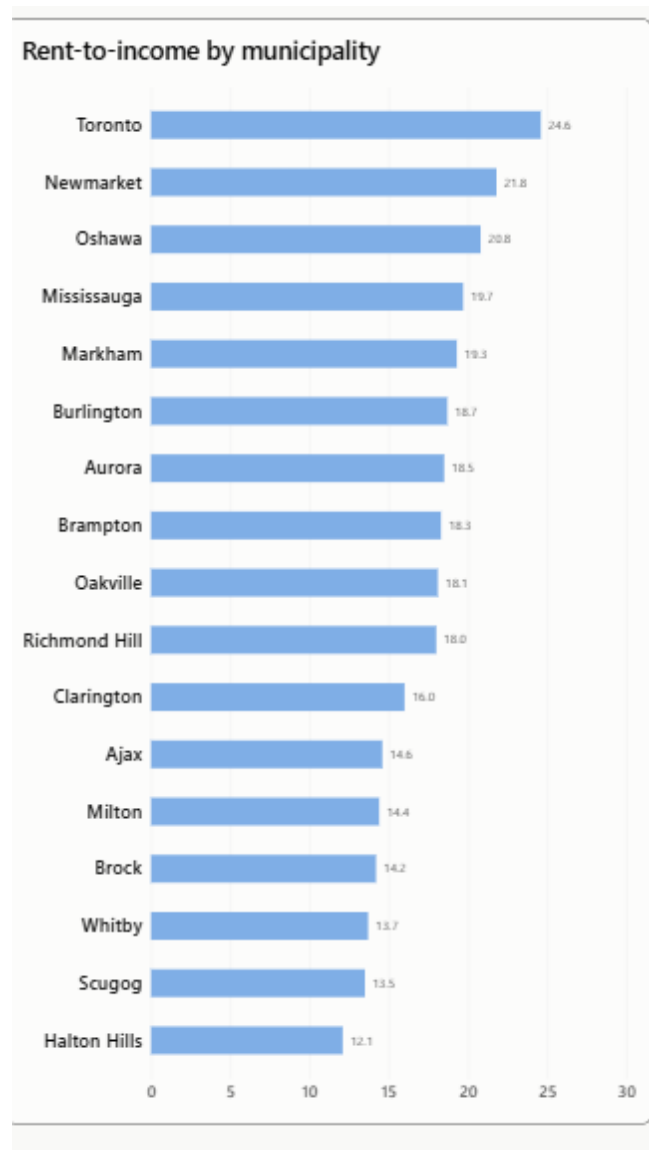


What it shows: Six headline numbers at a glance: highest and lowest rent-to-income ratio, highest renter stress, the municipality with the most rental choice (vacancy), the income needed for a 2-bedroom unit, and the widest gap between rent growth and income growth — each paired with the municipality it belongs to.

Why this chart type: Card visuals were used instead of a paragraph of text or a dense table because the goal here is immediate orientation. A reader should be able to glance at the top of the dashboard for five seconds and walk away knowing which cities are the extremes, before digging into any detail below.

Key insight: Toronto has the worst rent-to-income ratio (24.6%) in the region — not because its rent is the highest, but because its median income is the lowest of the major municipalities.

2. Rent-to-Income by Municipality



What it shows: A ranked comparison of rent-to-income ratio across the 17 municipalities with published 2025 rent data, sorted from least affordable (Toronto) to most affordable (Halton Hills).

Why this chart type: A horizontal bar chart was chosen because the task here is pure comparison across many categories with long labels (municipality names). Horizontal bars keep city names fully readable without rotating text, and sorting by value lets the eye immediately see the ranking rather than having to hunt for it.

Key insight: The ranking isn't simply 'biggest cities are least affordable.' Newmarket, a smaller municipality, ranks second-worst at 21.8%, ahead of much larger cities like Mississauga and Markham.

3. Renter Stress by Municipality

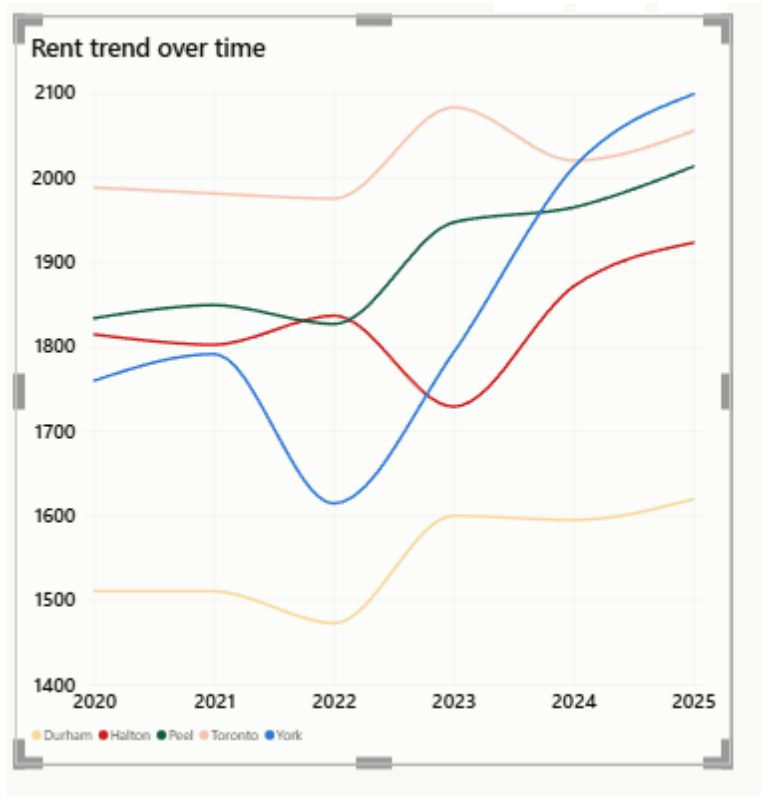
Renter stress by municipality	
Municipality	Renter stress % *
Richmond Hill	51.20
Vaughan	50.40
Markham	47.80
Oakville	45.80
Burlington	44.90
Aurora	44.10
East Gwillimbury	44.00
Whitchurch-Stouffville	43.30
Oshawa	42.70
Uxbridge	41.80
Milton	41.60
Clarington	40.60
Georgina	40.50
Caledon	40.40
Halton Hills	40.30
Toronto	40.00
Newmarket	39.50
Whitby	39.50
Mississauga	39.10
Pickering	38.40
King	37.90
Ajax	37.80
Scugog	37.50
Brampton	37.00
Brock	31.60

What it shows: The share of renter households in each municipality spending more than 30% of income on rent (the standard affordability threshold), covering all 25 municipalities, with conditional formatting banding values into red (highest stress), orange (moderate-high), and lighter shades for lower stress.

***Why this chart type:** A table with conditional formatting was used instead of another bar chart because this metric needed two things a bar chart doesn't give well: the exact percentage value for every one of the 25 municipalities, and a quick color-coded read of severity without needing to compare bar lengths by eye. The color bands let a viewer spot the worst-affected cities in under a second, while the numbers are still there for anyone who wants precision.*

Key insight: Renter stress is highest in the wealthiest-looking suburbs — Richmond Hill (51.2%), Vaughan (50.4%), and Markham (47.8%) — the opposite pattern from the rent-to-income chart. This is the paradox at the center of the project: a high median income pulls the aggregate rent-to-income ratio down and makes a city look affordable, even while a large share of its renters specifically are financially stretched.

4. Rent Trend Over Time



What it shows: Average 2-bedroom rent from 2020 to 2025 across the five GTA regions (Durham, Halton, Peel, Toronto, York), shown as five separate trend lines.

Why this chart type: A line chart was the natural choice because the question here is about change over a continuous time axis, not a comparison at a single point. Five distinct colored lines let the reader see both each region's individual trajectory and how the regions' rents have converged or diverged relative to each other since 2020.

Key insight: York's rent dropped sharply through 2021–2022 before climbing steeply past every other region by 2025, overtaking Toronto — a very different story than a single five-year average would tell.

Key Findings

- Toronto has the worst rent-to-income ratio in the GTA at 24.6%, driven by low median income rather than the highest rent.
- Halton Hills looks like the most affordable municipality at 12.1% rent-to-income, yet 40.3% of its renter households are still cost-burdened — proof that an affordable-looking average can sit on top of a stretched population.
- Newmarket now needs a \$95,000 household income to keep a 2-bedroom unit under the 30% affordability line, more than Toronto requires, despite Toronto's higher rent.
- Renter strain concentrates in the wealthiest suburbs: Richmond Hill, Vaughan, and Markham all show renter-stress rates above 47%, even though their aggregate income numbers look strong.
- The widest gap between rent growth and income growth, measured from 2015 to 2020, points to a sustained trend rather than a single-year anomaly — rent has been outpacing income for years in the hardest-hit municipality, not just recently.

Limitations & Data Notes

Income includes homeowners, who earn more than renters, so this understates renter burden. 2025 income is estimated by carrying 2020 census income forward with inflation. 2025 2-bedroom rent is published for only 17 of 25 municipalities — a blank means not published; however, CMHC data covers purpose-built rentals only, not condos or basement units.

These limitations are shown directly on the dashboard itself rather than buried in an appendix, because they change how the numbers should be read. Income figures include homeowners, who typically earn more than renters, so every rent-to-income ratio on this dashboard understates the burden renters specifically are carrying. 2025 income is an estimate (2020 census income carried forward with inflation), not a measured figure. 2025 2-bedroom rent is published for only 17 of the 25 municipalities — a blank means the data was never published, not that rent is zero. And CMHC's survey only covers purpose-built rental units, not condos or basement apartments, which make up a meaningful share of the GTA's actual rental supply.

Conclusion

The assumption that renters can simply 'move further out' to find affordability doesn't hold up against this data. Brampton, Halton, and Newmarket each break that assumption in a different way: one looks affordable on paper while quietly stressing its renters, another requires a higher income for a 2-bedroom unit than the city it's supposed to be a cheaper alternative to. GTA affordability isn't a single number, and a regional average is the fastest way to lose sight of the people living inside it.

The hardest decision in building this dashboard wasn't a visual choice — it was choosing which measure to lead with. Rent-to-income at median income says the region is broadly fine. Renter-specific stress data says a third to a half of renters in the most "affordable-looking" cities are financially stretched. Both are true at once; picking the one that actually answers the question people are asking is the real work of this kind of analysis.